
Getting started with learning

In the design phase, you may have already gained theoretical knowledge about the learning process and learning activities, and drawn up a plan to develop transdisciplinary teaching around a wicked problem. Now the groups are starting off, they as well - 'practice what you preace' - have to go through the activities, which you know from the design phase.

The diagram from the torch '*How do we learn?*' provides a guideline for the various activities a group can work on. First, you thoroughly get to know the central problem in the collaboration: visualise this and get to know the voices of all stakeholders. At the same time, you work on team building: make sure all project participants get to know each other well, both personally and substantively. What are their backgrounds, do they really understand each other? You often find that everyone just speaks their own language; developing a common language is a must. Only after this, the group can effectively start writing a project proposal, setting goals and making them concrete.

Some, especially students, see these phases as 'preparation' until you can finally 'get started'. As a result of this, introductory phases tend to be rushed through rather quickly. Be vigilant about this! Deep understanding of the central problem and strong team building are the foundations on which to build.

This is especially true if you move on to researching, designing and testing ideas. In this phase, the knowledge of various team members should come together through brainstorming, building, reflecting and presenting – then, really knowing and understanding each other is a must.

In the design phase, reflect as often as possible within your group: on your own learning, on your understanding of stakeholders with differing views, and on the product being worked on. Also reflect together with stakeholders not involved in the project. In these reflections, you can also monitor yourself – together with supervisors and coaches – the development of your learning process.

At the end of the collaboration, you put yourself out there even more: disseminate results via presentations, tangible or digital products and events. Although the project may be completely finished for some participants (especially for students who have completed their course), this is also the phase in which you should already look for starting points for a next, new transdisciplinary cycle. Only then, your knowledge and impact will continue to develop for the benefit of all stakeholders from your wicked problem.

Iterative learning

While going through all the learning activities, remember that transdisciplinary learning is iterative learning. When tackling complex problems, this is the only way forward. After all, complex problems are multifaceted and changeable. Therefore, you need to revisit the process regularly and keep adjusting your action plan during the project.